


**THE FUTURE BET**

- **Seven new passenger rail lines will run 4,000 km around the country**
- **Smaller cities on the way are expected to get a leg-up in trade, services and tourism**
- **A new freight rail line from West Bengal to Gujarat will speed up goods and cut costs**

Institute of Logistics & Transport.

India's inland waterways are set to expand further. Currently, 111 national waterways are operational, and over the next five years, 20 more will come online. Freight movement via waterways has surged from 18.1 MT in 2013-14 to 145.5 MT in 2024-25, a nearly 700 per cent increase, with operational length now exceeding 5,155 km. "The National Waterway-5 on the Mahanadi system has been on the cards for sometime now. The main challenge is maintaining adequate water in the 300-km stretch of the Brahmani river," says Rinkesh Roy, former chairman, Paradip Port Authority. In order for that to happen, analysts say a number of dams and barrages need to be constructed, which are long-gestation projects. But the economics is sound. Talcher being a largest hub of coal production of the Mahanadi Coalfields, more ways to evacuate the bulging output are needed to supplement the railways there. "The freight cost per tonne km via waterways is 20 per cent cheaper compared with railways and 60 per cent cheaper compared with roads," says Anand Kulkarni, director at Crisil Ratings.

These initiatives should not be viewed piecemeal. Taken together, they signal a long-term bet: scale, integration, and cleaner transport will cut logistics costs, boost mobility and also drive regional growth. ■



# The Creative Culture Push

**Digital and creative economy are being framed as the next frontier of employment and exports**

*By* **ANILESH S. MAHAJAN**

**Budget 2026 marks the first formal recognition of the Orange Economy** as a distinct pillar of India's economic strategy, with Rs 450 crore set aside to accelerate its growth. The term refers to industries that convert creativity, culture and intellectual property into economic value—spanning animation, visual effects, gaming, comics and extended reality (AVGC-XR), alongside design, digital media and live entertainment.

In her budget speech, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman highlighted that the AVGC-XR industry is projected to require two million additional skilled professionals by 2030. Yet India accounts for just a fraction of the global market—about $3 billion (Rs 27,000 crore)—prompting the government to target a 5 per cent share through creative clusters, tax neutrality for studios and export facilitation. To deepen the talent pipeline, the Indian Institute of Creative Technologies, Mumbai, will set up content cre-

**INDUSTRY SIZE**

**$3 BILLION**

*(₹27,000 crore)*

**Animation/ VFX/ gaming**

**BUDGET ALLOCATION**

**₹450 CRORE**



RAJWANT RAWAT